



Security Watch

Flash And Shockwave Vulnerabilities

The Problem

There is a security vulnerability in older versions of Adobe's (formerly Macromedia's) Flash and Shockwave players.

If you use Windows, you are more or less sure to have Flash on your system—whether or not you recall having installed it.

The program was redistributed with XP Service Packs 1 and 2, and with Windows 98.

The problem affects Flash Player versions 8.0.22.0 and earlier. To see what version you have installed, go to www.macromedia.com/software/flash/about/.

Shockwave versions 10.1.0.11 and earlier also have the problem. To check what version you have, go to www.macromedia.com/shockwave/welcome/.

The Damages

This is a critical update. If you have an older version installed, and you click on specially-crafted Flash or Shockwave links, a malicious attacker could hijack your browser and even take complete control over your computer.

The Solution

Update Flash Player by visiting <http://www.macromedia.com/go/getflashplayer8/>. To update your Shockwave Player, visit www.macromedia.com/shockwave/download/.

want much beyond what is available on OLPC's laptop, which includes a browser, e-mail client, word processor, IM, image viewer, media player, a programming tool, ...? Also, the fact that the \$100 laptop is hand-cranked cannot be dismissed.

Intel must have a good reason for getting into this market; how do they see the situation? What will dominate—the need for more software and content, or the price point? And most importantly, of all the offerings on hand, will any succeed in empowering the last billion?

POTENTIAL FOR HAVOC

RFID Tags Virus-Prone!

A group of Dutch researchers has discovered—and warned—that RFID tags can indeed be infected with viruses. A group under the guidance of Andrew Tanenbaum at the Amsterdam Free University made the world's first RFID malware publicly available for analysis. In a proof-of-concept paper presented at the IEEE Conference on Pervasive Computing and Communications on 15 March, the researchers warned that infected microchips could corrupt RFID databases and cause "major chaos" at airports and supermarkets.

It was widely presumed that RFID tags could not

become infected with a virus, because they only have a limited memory capacity. The group of researchers discovered that if certain vulnerabilities exist in RFID software, a tag can be purposefully infected with a virus by a prankster or criminal, which could infect the backend database used by the RFID software. From there, it can easily spread to other RFID tags.

In one scenario outlined by the researchers in the paper, the RFID-augmented labels used to expedite baggage handling can be targeted by a malicious person to cause chaos in busy airports.

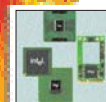
"Consider a malicious traveller who attaches a tiny RFID tag, pre-initialised with a virus, to a random person's suitcase before he checks it in. When the baggage-handling system's RFID reader scans the suitcase at a Y-junction in the conveyor-belt system to determine where to route it, the tag responds with the RFID virus, which could infect the airport's baggage database," the researchers explained.

"Then, all RFID tags produced as new passengers check in later in the day may also be infected. If any of these infected bags transit a hub, they will be rescanned there, thus infecting a different airport."

And thus, within a day, hundreds of airport databases all over the world could be infected! An RFID

HOT

Centrino Duo



Two cores are better than one, and the Centrino Duo has, well, two cores! The second core results in a performance increase of 30 per cent, and the processor features very efficient power-saving thanks to the lower operating voltage

Centrino

Why would you invest in technology that is three years old



and that has no deep sleep state—as in Centrino Duo? The old Centrino also consumes more power for the same workload compared to the Duo edition CPUs

virus could also carry a payload that damages the database and, for example, helps drug smugglers or terrorists hide their baggage from airline and government officials.

The findings mentioned above are controversial right now, and there might not be reason to get panicky. The trade association for automatic identification and mobility, AIM Global, has attempted to refute the key findings of the Dutch researchers.

"Many of the basic assumptions in the paper overlook a number of fundamental design features necessary in automatic data collection systems and good database design," asserted Dan Mullen, president of AIM Global.

Mullen suggested that



One Silly Question

"What would you exchange your computer for?"



"Definitely designer clothes"
Tanvi Ambavi



"A nice sports bike."
Madan Bangale



"Loads of jewellery"
Shruti Parekh



"Nothing short of the Sony Ericsson w800i"
Asim Narsinh



"Three wishes?"
Raveena Uchil